

HOLLY JOHNSON

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Design Systems Lead · Senior UX Designer · Tokens & Governance

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Design systems lead and product designer, 10+ years, most recently three and a half years of B2B SaaS at Penlink. Built Helios there from zero, a Figma component set taken to a published Angular library three products shipped on.

Owned the design architecture, the code standards underneath, and the voice the documentation was written in. Earlier, proposed and built NUcleus, a multi-brand design system still in use at the University of Nebraska System.

Partners with senior leadership to turn direction into work teams can build, including design system strategy and investment cases presented to the CPO and CTO.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Senior UX Designer

01/2023 - 08/2026

Penlink · Full-time, Remote

- Built Helios from zero, introducing Figma at Penlink and shipping the published Angular library behind three investigative products, adopted through platform modes and non-breaking versioned releases without pausing feature delivery.
 - Architected 200+ layered tokens, 50+ components, and 20+ shared patterns in Figma variables and SCSS, with normalized prop contracts, WCAG-informed ARIA, internationalization, and RTL, shipped to teams in the US, Canada, and Israel.
 - Designed CoAnalyst, Penlink's AI product surfaces, with the lead designer across chat, report view, agent workflow, streaming states, and refusal handling; led the saved-prompt and prompt-gallery patterns end to end.
 - Wrote the code architecture and standards behind the system and set its voice and tone, carrying roughly four designers' decisions to 150+ engineers through review practice and QA automation against documented contracts.
 - Applied Claude and MCP daily for repository and adoption scans, customer insights synthesis, and documentation.
 - Mentored designers, moved component critique into standing UX reviews, and presented design system strategy and investment cases to the CPO and CTO.
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Digital Design System Specialist

04/2022 - 01/2023

University of Nebraska System · Lincoln, NE

- Continued the NUcleus design system: standards, components, and support for teams building across 9 university brands, through a restructure that moved the role into the Office of the President.
 - Presented design system and brand work to the marketing VP, and mentored designers on the team.
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Lead Web Designer / Developer

05/2018 - 04/2022

University of Nebraska System · Lincoln, NE

- Proposed, built, and led NUcleus from the ground up: vision, roadmap, architecture, governance, and primitive, semantic, and component token layers in Figma variables and SCSS.
- Delivered NUcleus into the CMS platform institutes and departments used for their own sites, so shared components shipped with every new site; it survived a later CMS transition and handoff and remains in use.
- Reviewed 300+ feature implementations against system standards and intended user experience, and worked with product managers and engineers to prioritize enhancements and drive adoption.
- Led three direct reports across design and front-end development for the duration of the role.

Independent Consultant

01/2014 - Present

Freelance · Lincoln, NE

- Designed the 2024 biennial report for the National Strategic Research Institute, a DoD-designated center.

C O R E S K I L L S

Design systems strategy | Design system evolution | Governance & standards · Design token architecture | Component APIs & contracts | Versioned releases & rollout · Figma variables & libraries | Design-to-code & code standards | Design system tooling · Systems thinking | Reusable frameworks & patterns | Multi-product architecture · Product design | Product development | Business acumen · Artificial intelligence (AI) | AI-powered experiences | Agentic & agent workflows · Interaction design | Information architecture | Usability & visual design

T E C H N I C A L S K I L L S

Design and prototyping tools: Figma (variables, libraries, component APIs), design tokens, motion · AI tooling: Claude, MCP in daily product design practice · Front-end: Angular, HTML, CSS, SCSS, JSON, TypeScript / React (personal project)

Research and craft: customer insights, customer-centric discovery, opportunity framing, AI prototyping and validation, trust, transparency, user control, accessibility / WCAG, ARIA, i18n, localization, RTL, brand expression, content design, UX writing, voice, tone and writing standards, documentation, craft, legal and regulatory domains

Ways of working: cross-functional collaboration, collaborative critique, strategic thinking, leadership, delegation, mentoring, coaching, storytelling, executive presentation, customer-facing practice grounded in customer needs, consistent, trustworthy, committed delivery

E D U C A T I O N

Associate of Applied Science [AAS], Graphic Design and Media Arts · Southeast Community College 2016

Paralegal Studies, bachelor's coursework · Doane College

E A R L I E R E X P E R I E N C E & A W A R D S

Prism Award, Consumer Marketing Campaigns · American Marketing Association · 05/2022

Adjunct Instructor · Southeast Community College, Lincoln, NE · 04/2017 - 12/2022

Communications Designer · Nebraska Department of Education, Lincoln, NE · 11/2012 - 03/2017

Legal Assistant, Legal & Enforcement · Nebraska Liquor Control Commission · 05/2005 - 11/2012